

Response Letter with Annotations

Citation (APA format, using Zotero or other bibliography software)

Chen, H. T., Guo, L., & Su, C. C. (2020). Network agenda setting, partisan selective exposure, and opinion repertoire: The effects of pro-and counter-attitudinal media in Hong Kong. *Journal of Communication*, 70(1), 35-59.

Annotations

1. Purposes

a. Motivation (one-sentence summary)

The motivation of this study is to investigate the NAS(network agenda setting) effect of partisan media (pro-attitudinal media) on individuals' own and oppositional argument repertoire and how these effects differ between individuals who engage in partisan selective exposure and those who do not.

b. Specific Rationale (several bullet points)

- This study sets the context in Hong Kong and mainland China and extend the NAS to non-western context
- The political landscape in Hong Kong (tension between pro-establishment and the pro-democracy camps) offers a suitable context to examine the NAS effect and partisan selective exposure.
- The network agenda-setting model suggests that salience of the interrelationships between objects and attributes can also be transferred from news media to public agenda.
- Selective exposure suggests that people tend to selectively expose themselves to like-minded opinions and thus are more susceptible to pro-attitudinal media. This suggests that especially for individuals who engage in partisan selective exposure, individuals' opinion repertoire should match the attribute networks of pro-attitudinal media. On the contrary, for those who do not engage in partisan selective exposure, their opinion repertoire, especially toward oppositional others, should be a better match with counter-attitudinal media.

c. Research Questions and/or Hypotheses

- H1: The attribute network of the pro-establishment media is positively associated with the attribute network that represents pro-establishment supporters' own opinion repertoire.
- H2: The attribute network of the pro-democracy media is positively associated with the attribute network that represents pro-democracy supporters' own opinion repertoire.
- H3: The attribute network of pro-attitudinal media is positively associated with the attribute network that represents one's own opinion repertoire among those who engage in partisan selective exposure.
- H4: The attribute network of pro-attitudinal media is positively associated with the attribute network that represents the oppositional opinion repertoire among those who engage in partisan selective exposure.

- H5: The attribute network of counter-attitudinal media is positively associated with the attribute network that represents the oppositional opinion repertoire among those who do not engage in partisan selective exposure.
- RQ1: What is the relationship between the attribute network of counterattitudinal media and the attribute network that represents one's own opinion repertoire among those who do not engage in partisan selective exposure?
 - Identify IV, DV, mediator, moderator
- IV: the attribute network of pro- and counter- attitudinal media
- DV: individuals' own and oppositional opinion repertoire- how one thinks of an issue and how one perceives the way oppositional others think of the issue.
- Moderator: whether individuals engage in partisan selective exposure or not.
 - Identify specific relationships among variables

2. Method

a. Research Design

- Experiment: conditions, manipulations, etc.
- Survey: cross-sectional, longitudinal, etc.
- Content analysis: data source, etc.
- ...

The study employed a content analysis of media coverage about the Hong Kong-mainland China during 19th NCCPC, as well as survey data conducted after 19th NCCPC). A network analysis was also conducted.

b. IV, content analysis of news articles from 30 outlets

- This study includes 30 media outlets from the news brand list in the Digital News Report survey.
- Ideological tendency of each outlet was determined based on previous studies
- Developed a keyword list about Hong Kong-mainland China relationship and searched in the databases WiseNews and Crimson Hexagon to collect news articles
- A **stratified random sample** was used, drawing one-quarter of the articles from each outlet, resulting in a total of 2,035 articles (20.5% pro-democracy, 21.5% neutral, and 58% pro-establishment).
- Graduate students coded whether each article is relevant to Hong Kong-mainland China relationship, and whether it mentioned any of the 16 sub-topics defined

c. Operationalization and Measures of DVs and moderators through survey data

- Survey conducted by Survey Sampling International, with a **stratified quota sampling** applied. In total, 1014 participants completed the survey(759 included in the final analysis, with those in the neutral group excluded).
- Measurements
 - Partisanship: self reported political party- pro-democratic, politically neutral(excluded), or pro-establishment

- Indices of media consumption: participants were asked to report the frequency of consumption of 35 media outlets on a 6-Likert scale. Based on this, three indices of media consumption were calculated
 - Pro-democracy media consumption
 - Pro-establishment media consumption
 - Neutral media consumption
- Index of partisan selective exposure
 - First, three ratio scores, pro-attitudinal, counter-attitudinal, and neutral media exposure were calculated by dividing one particular type of exposure by the total media consumption.
 - Second, binary coding
 - If the pro-attitudinal media exposure > 0.5 , then 1
 - If < 0.5 , then 0
- Opinion repertoire
 - Own opinion repertoire and oppositional others' opinion repertoire
 - Asked participants to come up with 5 sub-topics and 5 the oppositional others would come up with
 - Their responses were manually coded into the 16 predetermined sub-topics
 - Asked participants to make connections between sub-topics and indicate the strength of associations between them.

d. Analysis-Network analysis

- Creating matrices for media agenda: calculated based on the frequency of the two sub-topics' co-occurrence in the same article
- Creating matrices for public agenda: sum of association values for each pair of sub-topics indicated by all respondents within each group
 - In total 8 matrices, $2(\text{pro-democracy, pro-establishment}) \times 2(\text{selective, non-selective exposure}) \times 2(\text{own opinion, oppositional opinion})$
- MRQAP regression model is used to test hypotheses

3. Results and Conclusions

a. Answers to RQs and Hypotheses

- H1:
 - Supported: The attribute network of pro-establishment Hongkongers was positively and significantly correlated to the pro-establishment media ($\beta = .29$, $p < .05$), which explained 22% of the variance.
- H2:
 - Supported: The attribute network of pro-democracy Hongkongers was positively correlated with the prodemocracy media ($\beta = .17$, $p < .05$) and explained 21% of the variance.
- H3:
 - supported: For both pro-establishment and pro-democracy supporters, the attribute network that represented their own opinion repertoire was positively

associated with the corresponding attribute network of pro-attitudinal media (Model 2a-pro-establishment supporters: $\beta = .31, p < .05$; Model 2b-pro-democracy supporters: $\beta = .46, p < .05$)

- H4:
 - Supported: For pro-establishment supporters who engaged in partisan selective exposure, the attribute network of the pro-establishment media was positively associated with their attribute network of the oppositional opinion repertoire ($\beta = .14, p < .05$);
 - For pro-democracy supporters who engaged in partisan selective exposure, the attribute network of the pro-democracy media was positively associated with their attribute network of the oppositional opinion repertoire ($\beta = .25, p < .05$)
- H5:
 - Supported: For those who did not engage in partisan selective exposure, pro-establishment supporters' attribute networks of the oppositional opinion repertoire were positively related to the attribute networks of the pro-democracy media ($\beta = .61, p < .05$)
 - For those who did not engage in partisan selective exposure, pro-democracy supporters' attribute networks of the oppositional opinion repertoire were positively related to the attribute networks of the pro-establishment media ($\beta = .61, p < .05$)
- RQ1: the results are mixed
 - For pro-establishment supporters who did not engage in partisan selective exposure, the attribute network of one's own opinion repertoire was not significantly related to the attribute network of the counter-attitudinal (pro-democracy) media; but **negatively associated with** the attribute network of the **pro-attitudinal (pro-establishment) media** ($\beta = -.54, p < .05$).
 - For pro-democracy supporters who did not engage in partisan selective exposure, the attribute network of one's own opinion repertoire was **significantly associated with** the attribute network of the **counter-attitudinal (pro-establishment) media** ($\beta = .20, p < .05$).

b. Include Key Figures/Tables

Table 1

Results of Multiple Regression Quadratic Assignment Procedure Analysis on the Attribute Network of One's Own Opinion Repertoire

Attribute Networks of Partisan Supporters	Attribute Networks of Partisan Media	B	β	Adjusted R^2
All respondents				
Model 1a, pro-establishment supporters, $n=198$	Pro-establishment media	7.20 [*]	.29 [*]	.22 ^{***}
	Pro-democracy media	3.51	.24	—
	Neutral media	28.49 ^{**}	.94 ^{**}	—
Model 1b, pro-democracy supporters, $n=561$	Pro-establishment media	7.15	.09	.21 ^{***}
	Pro-democracy media	8.75 [*]	.17 [*]	—
	Neutral media	71.68 [*]	.70 [*]	—
Selective exposure group				
Model 2a, pro-establishment supporters, $n=146$	Pro-establishment media	7.10 [*]	.31 [*]	.19 ^{**}
	Pro-democracy media	1.45	.16	—
	Neutral media	19.94 ^{**}	.86 ^{**}	—
Model 2b, pro-democracy supporters, $n=97$	Pro-establishment media	2.66	.14	.20 ^{**}
	Pro-democracy media	3.71 [*]	.46 [*]	—
	Neutral media	19.29 ^{**}	.96 ^{**}	—
Non-selective exposure group				
Model 3a, pro-establishment supporters, $n=52$	Pro-establishment media	-2.07 [*]	-.54 [*]	.19 ^{**}
	Pro-democracy media	.10	.01	—
	Neutral media	8.55 ^{**}	.89 ^{**}	—
Model 3b, pro-democracy supporters, $n=464$	Pro-establishment media	6.09 [*]	.20 [*]	.20 ^{**}
	Pro-democracy media	-3.44	-.10	—
	Neutral media	52.39 [*]	.61 [*]	—

Note: The attribute network of the neutral media is included as a control. ^{*} $p < .05$; ^{**} $p < .01$; ^{***} $p < .001$.

Table 2

Results of Multiple Regression Quadratic Assignment Procedure Analysis on the Attribute Network of the Oppositional Opinion Repertoire

Attribute Networks of Partisan Supporters	Attribute Networks of Partisan Media	B	β	Adjusted R^2
Selective exposure group				
Model 1a, pro-establishment supporters, $n=146$	Pro-establishment media	1.63 [*]	.14 [*]	.17 ^{**}
	Pro-democracy media	-.91	-.08	—
	Neutral media	4.03 [*]	.37 [*]	—
Model 1b, pro-democracy supporters, $n=97$	Pro-establishment media	.04	.02	.25 ^{***}
	Pro-democracy media	1.54 [*]	.25 [*]	—
	Neutral media	3.05 [*]	.48 [*]	—
Non-selective exposure group				
Model 2a, pro-establishment supporters, $n=52$	Pro-establishment media	-.69 [*]	-.37 [*]	.11 [*]
	Pro-democracy media	2.82 [*]	.61 [*]	—
	Neutral media	.18	.04	—
Model 2b, pro-democracy supporters, $n=464$	Pro-establishment media	2.10 [*]	.21 [*]	.19 ^{**}
	Pro-democracy media	-9.83 [*]	-.44 [*]	—
	Neutral media	18.42 ^{**}	.80 ^{**}	—

Note: The attribute network of the neutral media is included as a control. ^{*} $p < .05$; ^{**} $p < .01$; ^{***} $p < .001$.

Figure E1(Appendix). Effects of partisan media agenda networks on the attribute networks of one's own opinion repertoire.

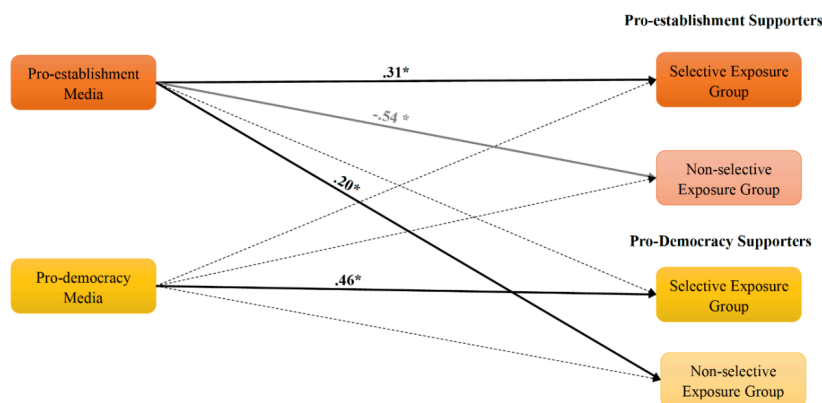
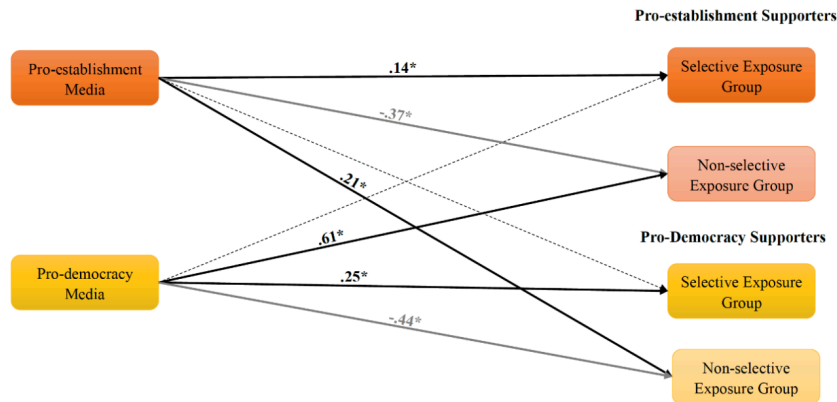


Figure E2 (Appendix). Effects of partisan media agenda networks on the attribute networks of the oppositional opinion repertoire.



c. Authors' Conclusions

- Overall, the results show the presence of the NAS effect in the Hong Kong context. Specifically, the effects varied by pro-attitudinal and counter-attitudinal media, and by partisan Hongkongers, with or without engaging in partisan selective exposure.
- For those engaged in partisan selective exposure, pro-attitudinal media was significantly related to not only how people think of the issue, but also how people think of the way the oppositional others perceive the issue.
- For those not engaged in selective exposure, counter-attitudinal media was significantly associated with the perspectives of the oppositional others.

4. Discussion

a. Implications

- Test NAS model: the news media are able to transfer the salience of a network of attributes, not just the salience of individual items to the public agenda.
- Extend NAS model to a non-western context
- A new way to measure attribute associations: ask participants self-report how they associated attributes and the degree of association
- First study to consider individuals' partisan selective exposure in examining the NAS model and found that selective exposure plays a significant role in the network agenda-setting effect.
- This study examined the NAS effect not only on individuals' own opinion repertoire but also on their thoughts about how oppositional others perceive the issue.
 - The findings suggest that exposure to counter-attitudinal media can help better understand the oppositional opinion repertoire, in line with the counter-attitudinal media.
- The mixed results for RQ1 suggest that cross-cutting exposure could also promote one's own understanding. But the effects could be limited. For example, the pro-democracy

media's network agenda was not related to the pro-establishment supporters' own opinion repertoire.

b. Limitations

- Not causal effect: the analysis cannot rule out possible reverse causality from the public agenda to the media agenda.
- This study only examined aggregate-level agenda-setting effects but cannot fully explain individual-level NAS effects.
- Binary classification of selective exposure or non-selective exposure.
- Possible effects of individual overall amounts of media exposure.
- The limitations of survey: self-report bias due to social desirability and the difficulty of recalling the consumed media content.

c. Future Directions

- The differences and similarities between neutral and partisan media and their relative impact warrant further examination.
 - This paper did exploratory examination and found the higher similarities between neutral media and pro-democracy media concerning attribute networks. In this sense, the effect of pro-democracy media could have been underestimated because more pro-democracy information could come from neutral media.
- Panel design to examine causality.
- Panel design to examine individual-level NAS effects.
- Instead of binary classification of selective exposure or non-selective exposure, future studies can further classify participants into different selective exposure levels and different types.
- Concerning the limitations of self-report surveys, future studies can consider experimental designs, naturalistic data collection, and log tracking to measure media consumption.

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Response Letter (~600 words)

- Your assessment of the study
- Weaknesses
- Other notes

This study examined the network agenda setting (NAS) effects of pro-attitudinal and counter-attitudinal media on partisan Hong Kongers' own opinion repertoire and their perceptions of oppositional others' opinion repertoire. It also explored how these effects vary depending on whether individuals engage in partisan selective exposure. The results supported all hypotheses and confirmed the presence of NAS effects.

I found this study theoretically profound, as it combines network agenda setting theory, selective exposure, as well as deliberation to develop its research questions and hypotheses. The examination of network agenda setting theory in a non-western context is indeed a significant contribution from my perspective. As mentioned by the authors, most previous research on network agenda setting has been conducted in the U.S. Although the polarized media context in Hong Kong, featuring pro-democracy and pro-establishment media, appears rather similar to US polarized media landscape, the political nuances, such as the asymmetric power balance between the two sides and its connection to Hong Kong-main land China relations, provide a unique backdrop for testing NAS and selective exposure theory.

I also appreciate that the authors used both survey and content analysis to collect data and transformed the data into matrices suitable for network analysis. Interestingly, the data collected are always not inherently applicable to network analysis and require pre-processing to be converted into network-analysis-ready format. It is also eye-opening that MRQAP can be used to test the causal or correlational relationships between variables in network form.

For the weaknesses, the authors have already thoroughly reflected on the limitations of the method in the paper. First, the cross-sectional design of this study cannot support causal conclusions about media agenda effects on public agenda, because it cannot rule out the possible reverse effects of the public agenda on the media agenda or other confounding variables. Second, another main limitation is the self-report bias in the survey data. This study mainly relied on respondents' self-reported media consumption and self-identified sub-topics, as well as their associations, to measure partisan selective exposure and their opinion repertoire. However, these self-report measurements could be biased due to social desirability and the difficulty of recalling the consumed media content. In addition, participants were asked to provide open-ended answers about relevant topics, which were then manually coded into 16 pre-defined categories. I am concerned about subjectivity in coding and potential force-fitting, as the open-ended responses may not align well with the pre-defined categories. One particularly interesting aspect to me is that participants were asked to indicate the degree of association between each pair of topics. According to the authors, this mind-mapping method better captures the explicit associations between objects, compared to the commonly-used approach of measuring implicit associations

based on co-occurrence frequencies in survey responses. Nevertheless, I think asking participants to self-report the degree of association between topics is kind of abstract and cognitively demanding, and may result in arbitrary or unreliable responses. In this sense, alternative approaches that enable the collection of more objective data could be employed to capture participants' media consumption and selective exposure more accurately, such as passive metering data used for individual level web visits (e.g., Guess, 2021).

Another point that could be strengthened is the explanation of the importance of attribute networks. Although network agenda setting theory highlights the theoretical significance of studying salience transfer among interrelationships between attributes, it remains somewhat unclear why this matters in practice, and how the connections between different topics contribute to understanding the HongKong-mainland China relationship. I feel that if the authors provided more in-depth interpretation of what these connections represent and why they matter, the results would be more socially and politically meaningful.